Does the regional stunting mean depend on who you count?

Two-page brief for programme directors. UN SDG global indicator database, indicator 2.2.1, eight East African countries, 2000 to 2024. Public data, reproducible script, no synthetic values.

Finding 1. The headline regional mean of latest-year stunting prevalence is 30.2 per cent. Restricting the same frame to the better-performing half of countries gives 23.2 per cent. Seven percentage points of regional reality appear or disappear with a filter, while every underlying figure stays correct. Any regional average quoted to you is a sampling decision, and you are entitled to ask which one.

Finding 2. Reporting recency changes nothing on this indicator, and that silence is informative. Indicator 2.2.1 is a modelled estimate with every country-year cell populated, so there is no missingness for a recency filter to act on. Completeness here is a property of the estimation method. On survey-reported indicators the same filter would delete exactly the countries in crisis, which is where the need is greatest.

Finding 3. The between-country spread, 17.9 to 58.5 per cent, is wider than any within-country trend over the period. A single regional number therefore conceals more than it reveals, and programme allocation based on it will misallocate by construction.

Quantity	Value	What it licenses
Regional mean, all eight countries	30.2 per cent	The defensible headline
Regional mean, better half only	23.2 per cent	Nothing. A filter, not a finding
Burundi minus Kenya, 95 per cent interval	-275.7 points, -406 to -150	A real gap, size bounded
Within-country annual change, fixed effects	-4.22 points per year	Trend description, not policy effect
Minimum detectable effect at available n	521.1 points	What an evaluation here could see
Difference-in-differences, 2013 teaching design	-186.7 points	Nothing causal. Pre-trends fail, disclosed

Recommendation. Publish regional aggregates only with a coverage footnote naming excluded units and their share of the population, and show a bounded range rather than a point where reporting is incomplete. Commission evaluation designs against the minimum detectable effect above, not against the effect anyone hopes for.

Limitations. Unweighted means; mixed latest years across countries; modelled estimates; serial correlation makes intervals optimistic; the difference-in-differences row is a teaching design whose parallel-trends assumption fails and is disclosed as failing. Reproduction: analysis scripts in weeks/week01 to weeks/week06 of the public repository.